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TRAVELLING LONG TO GET INKED

Over the last two to three weeks, migrant workers in Chennai have been etching travel plans to vote in their hometowns. Associations representing them are seeking additional trains to ensure their long journey to the voting booth is smooth. **P6**



GARBAGE ON A RIVER TRAIL

Two Chennai residents find themselves carrying out a cleanliness audit of a 400-metre riverside at Gandhi Nagar in Adyar. **P2**



MTC bus terminus at Vijayanagar junction in Velachery. PHOTO: SRINATH . M

Bring northern parts of Chennai 'closer' to Velachery

Residents of 100 Feet Road note that MTC services from the southern parts of Chennai to the city's northern parts that passed through Velachery have dwindled

B. GANGADHARAN

Residents of 100 Feet Road in Velachery find the northern parts of the Chennai slipping out of their range. And as residents are having a shopping list of changes they want to see in the neighbourhoods, ready for candidates of political parties, residents of 100 Feet Road in Velachery are seeking that north Chennai be "brought closer" to them.

Many summers ago, travelling to areas such as Royapuram in north Chennai did not take much of an effort as a raft of bus services were being operated to Broadway, Thiruvottiyur, Royapuram and surrounding areas from Sithalappakkam, Ottiyambakkam, East Tambaram, Kovilambakkam, Madipakkam and Madambakkam,

Commuters from Velachery have to head to Little Mount to board buses to destinations such as Royapuram in north Chennai. To reach Thiruvottiyur, commuters have to disembark at the Chennai Central railway station bus stop or at the Royapuram terminus and board another bus

through Velachery.

But today, the services are as good as non-existent, as only a handful of them are still on the road. Even these services are being operated only in the morning, and nowhere to be seen in the evening.

Route D51X, plying from Sithalappakkam, E51 from Ottiyambak-

kam, 51J from Madambakkam, and 51D from East Tambaram to Royapuram, is spotted only once in the morning at the Vijaya Nagar bus terminus, and in the evenings, these services do not ply.

Commuters from Velachery have to head to Little Mount to board buses to destinations such as Royapuram in north Chennai. To reach Thiruvottiyur, commuters have to disembark at the Chennai Central railway station bus stop or at the Royapuram terminus and board another bus.

I request the authorities at Metropolitan Transport Corporation to look into this issue and do the needful at the earliest to alleviate the problems faced by commuters from Velachery and the adjoining regions.

B. Gangadharan is a resident of Sakthi Vijayalakshmi Nagar, Velachery.

Cricket coaching camp at Gandhi Nagar



The Gandhi Nagar Cricket and Sports Club is conducting its Summer Coaching Camp 2026 at the Club's ground at No. 63-A, 4th Main Road in Gandhi Nagar, Adyar.

Stretching from April 13 to May 29, the camp is for boys and girls in

the age group six to 19.

The coaching sessions will be from 6.15 a.m. to 8.15 a.m.

For details, call C.S. Ravi, honorary secretary at 8754407654 / K. Balakrishnan, honorary joint secretary at 9444824838

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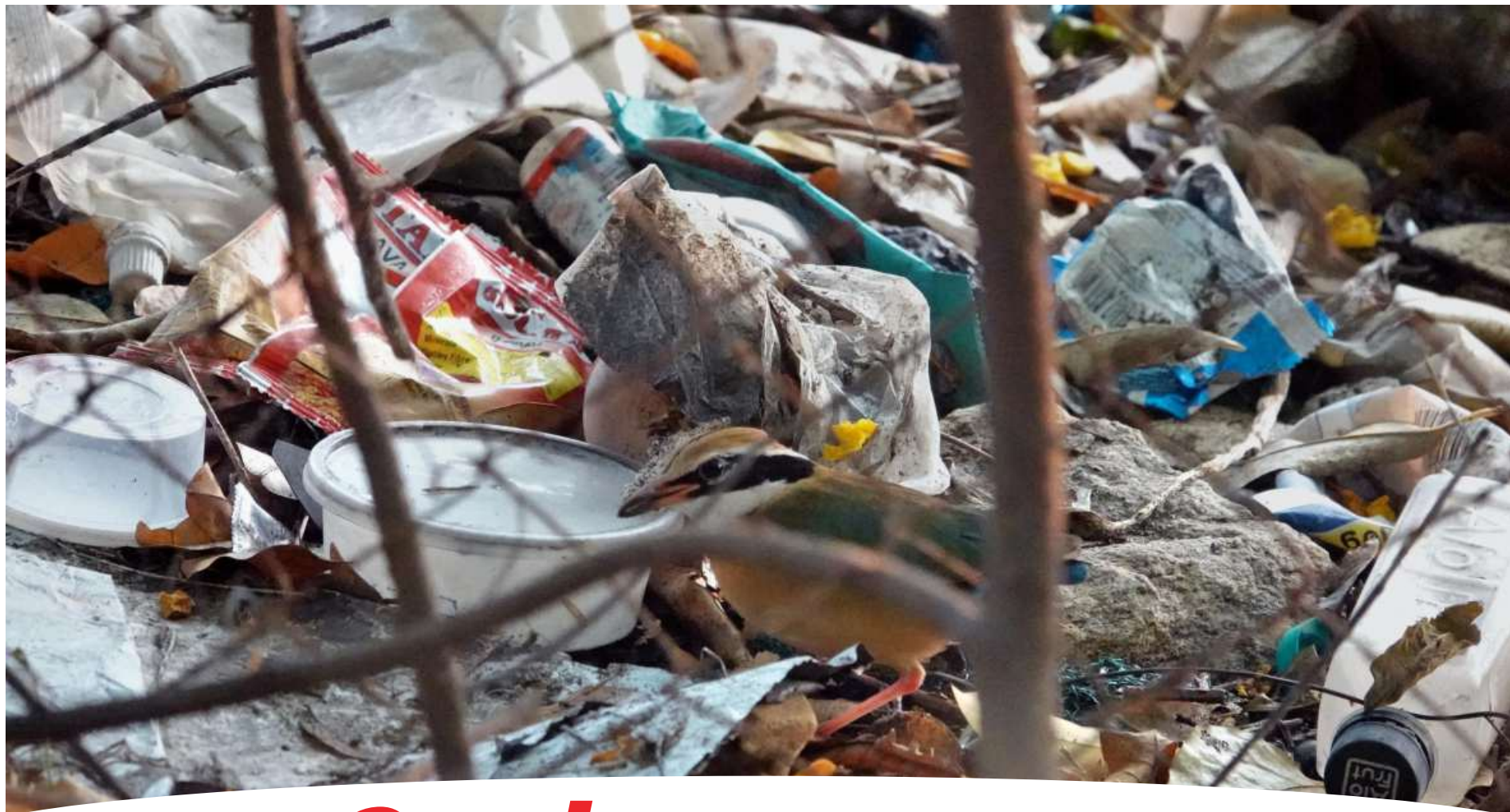
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PRINCE FREDERICK

Garbage on a river trail

Two Chennai residents find themselves carrying out a cleanliness audit of a 400-metre riverside at Gandhi Nagar in Adyar

Trust a birder to make a short trail longer by taking measured steps, extending their pauses and lingering at every square inch of the landscape, their eyes gulping in ancillary details while scanning for feathers.

Given what they notice at every outing, the local municipal administration should reserve a seat or two for birders at spaces where table-thumping official-citizen interactions over civic affairs, particularly waste management, happen.

Recently, in Chennai, two bird-watchers made a short 400-metre trail along Adyar river in Gandhi Nagar seem longer than the 40,000 kilometre Pan-American Highway.

Both members of Madras Naturalists' Society, Sujatha Padmanabhan (a Teynampet resident) and Jayashree Santhanam (an Adyar resident) had set out on the trail looking for two migrants, an Indian pitta and an Orange-headed thrush that were reportedly haunting that space like the Wiltshire ghost.

They spotted these birds to their delight; and they spotted something else to their dismay. Both the good and the bad have been documented with photographs.

This trail by the side of the Adyar river had its entry point near St. Patrick's School. Talking to *The Hindu Downtown*, Sujatha notes that the path, which is a well-laid walking track, runs along a fence marking off the river area, and it struts past a park. Sujatha makes it

clear that when they started on the walk, they had only birdwatching on their mind. And when they ended it, the pursuit of feathers shared mind space with the idea of an environmental audit of the trail.

Here are the salient features of the report by the duo, enunciated by Sujatha.

"The waste was overwhelmingly non-biodegradable. It was predominantly plastic wrappers, water

bottles and disposable containers. This waste was found on the riverside of the fence, and it was sitting on the land near the waters. The location of the garbage makes it largely a case of river-borne accumulation and not one of direct dumping by visitors. Because of its location, this garbage is out of the reach of regular, everyday conservancy operations. But mechanisms have to be devised to clear this garbage, else the risk of biomagnification would shoot up."

While river-borne accumulation seems an explanation that is more than reasonable, going by some of the waste, plastic cups to be precise, it is possible that at night, tipplers sit by the side of the fence to

open the bottle and fling the remains of the indulgence over the fence. While the Adyar river (the creek, to be precise) is the diadem in the crown called Tholkappia Poonga, a grand CRRT offering that has indubitably added lustre to the city, it seems odd that parts of the riverside such as this that lie not too far from that grand eco-stage are allowed to wear flannels woven with squalor and neglect.

'This could be the result of reverse flow'

A Water Resources Department (WRD) official notes that the garbage accumulating at this section of the Adyar river could be the result of reverse flow. His conclusion is predicated on the premise that a cross-boom installed at Kotturpuram would not allow waste flowing in from there to travel to the spot.

On whether WRD can address the issue of waste accumulation at this spot, he notes WRD is allowed to carry out dredging work in the river only around the monsoon.

He notes that GCC clears garbage using the aforementioned cross boom, installed during the CRRT project, and the civic body has the machinery to clean this spot too.



An Orange-headed thrush (top) and an Indian pitta on a trail along Adyar river in Gandhi Nagar that is overrun with garbage. PHOTOS: SUJATHA PADMANABHAN



▼
Bags of garbage and (below) grey water at this OSR park in Karapakkam.

‘Ensure proper maintenance of OSR park in Karapakkam’

Bundles of garbage are piled high at this green space; grey water is also discharged into it, says a resident of Karapakkam

RAGHAV

A public park is the last place one would expect to see a visible flow of grey water; and bundles of garbage piled high. But these are sad realities at an OSR park attached to a gated community in Karapakkam.

Many a time, during my visits to this park on the OSR land at Doshi Risington, I have noticed discharge of grey water at several areas within the green space, especially where the cricket pitch is located.

This might be treated water, but stagnant water is conducive environment for breeding of mosquitoes and the spread of dengue. I contracted dengue last year in the summer season, and I have a reason to believe it has to do with my regular visits to this OSR park.

Without mowing, grass used to grow wild. Lights are often switched off at night and the park closed well before closing time.

I request Greater Chennai Corporation to look into the matter and ensure this gated community takes proper care of this public park.

Raghav is a resident of Karapakkam



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LIFFY THOMAS

Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit has added a fresh feather to its cap. On March 30, when the Mada Streets around Kapaleeswarar Temple in Mylapore were teeming with devotees for the Arubathimooavar procession, these volunteers took a strategic position, stationing themselves in the compound of Indian Bank on North Mada Street. Their presence equalled safely. With a public address system, they were continually urging devotees to keep their children safe in crowded spaces. By the end of the day, they had helped reunite three children with their parents. And 25 others who are in their second children: they are senior citizens.

"Two boys and one girl; and 25 senior citizens, some of them having difficulty walking," 76-year-old Thambi K. Parthasarathy spells out the details. Parthasarathy is a core member of Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit; his voice is hoarse from hours of shouting.

For more than a decade now, Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit, established by Late M.G. Shankar, has

made it a point to volunteer during the Arubathimoovar procession, the highlight of the Panguni festival, where thousands of devotees throng the streets. Annadhanam is the core activity carried out by this informal group of friends who live in and around Mylapore. While performing a raft of activities, the unit adds a service to it, ensuring children do not go missing in the crowds by asking parents to be vigilant and when children do go missing, it finds and reunites children with their parents.

“It was Late T.C. Vijayan, former MLA and a member of the Unit, who suggested that we do this service during the Panguni festival as

the crowds are huge, and the loud-speaker was set up at only one point then," says Thambi Parthasarathy.

Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit has close to 120 members, and a majority of them have moved to other parts of the city, but they make it in attendance during Panguni.

In his early 70s and an active volunteer, Santhanam Krishnan moved from Mandaveli to Kottivakkam some years ago, but every year during Panguni he is around to support the volunteering effort.

“Late Shankar and I used to take a pilgrimage to Sabrimala Temple in Kerala and he motivated me to

get involved in the activities of the Unit," says Santhanam, who is president of the Unit, adding that they volunteer on a rotational basis.

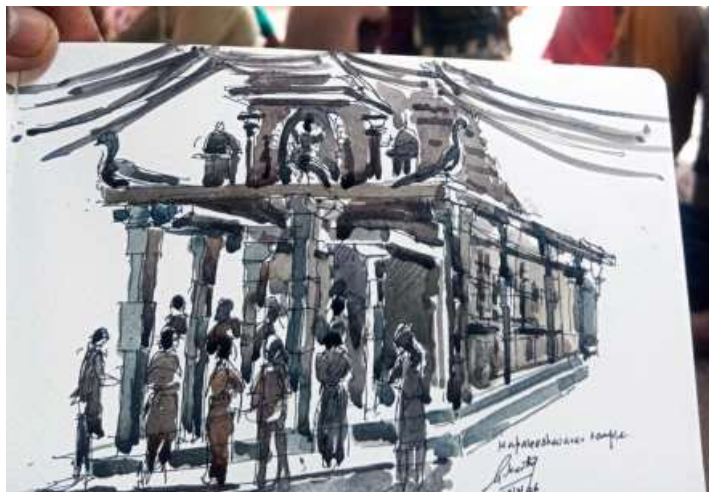
With the permission of the temple management and the police, Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit got additional speakers installed at all the four mada veedis for the announcements to be heard in all corners. The police has a booth near the temple where it does its own announcements. Currently, eight speakers are installed in each of the streets, all relayed from one point by volunteers.

Over the years, the volunteers have tweaked the way they make the announcements, thereby keep-

Rescue operation amidst the festivity

With a sea of devotees flowing through the Mada streets around Kapaleeswarar temple for the Arubathimooval procession, these volunteers drawn from Mandaveli and surrounding areas keep their voices primed for continual announcements

A 'sketch' of a festival





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Travelling long to get inked

Over the last two to three weeks, migrant workers in Chennai have been etching travel plans to vote in their hometowns. Associations representing them are seeking additional trains to ensure their long journey to the voting booth is smooth

LIFFY THOMAS

When election dates were announced on March 15, Kottivakkam resident and general secretary of Confederation of Tamilnadu Malayalee Associations Anwar M.P. was furiously scrolling down IRCTC website to book four train tickets to his hometown in Kannur district of Kerala. A resident of Chennai for the last three decades, the businessman makes travel plans to his native place every election season (that includes panchayat elections) sufficiently ahead of time.

Kerala goes to the hustings on April 9, as do Assam and Puducherry. Further down the “poll procession” are Tamil Nadu (April 23) and West Bengal (April

23 and 29).

Travel plans are being meticulously etched by residents of Chennai with their votes parked in other states. And associations representing the interests of those from these states who have “pitched tent” in Chennai for work and business note that with intervention by the Tamil Nadu government and Southern Railway, these travel plans need not be as stressful as they cur-

Poll-related travel plans are not always about tickets. Soaring prices of flight tickets around this time and lack of certainty about train tickets are encouraging voters to undertake long road trips to cast the ballot

rently are.

The Confederation of Tamilnadu Malayalee Associations has made a representation to the State Government to run additional trains to clear the rush of migrants wanting to vote in their hometowns. “This year, we made the representation more than two months ago so that there is ample time to press more trains into service,” says Anwar.

While Southern Railway does operate special trains during festivals and election season, many say the announcement on additional trains is made at the eleventh hour, which detracts from the usefulness of this exercise.

As Easter, Assembly Polls and Vishu come in quick succession, Anwar says there’s demand for bus and train tickets to Kerala.

Natvar Thidar, aged 44 and working as a cook in Chennai for the last 15 years, notes: “I paid extra money to an agent and got a confirmed ticket on Coromandel Express.”

“There are less number of trains to north Malabar and towards Mangalore, so we have made a representation to run trains on these routes in particular. We also need Vande Bharat on this network,” says Anwar.

A similar demand has been raised by the Assam Association Chennai, they want additional Durgam Express/Rajdhani Express/Vande Bharat Express to Guwahati.

Mini Bengal in Chennai

In Sowcarpet and Park Town, Tarun Kumar Das has been working with the community of Bengalis to encourage them to travel to their hometown to cast their vote. He says there are close to 30,000 Bengalis working mainly with

gold manufacturing outlets. “At least 70% of them have their vote in Bengal and we have already started speaking to them to see if they can start making arrangements to travel home,” says Das, who is vice-president of Rexine and Bag Manufacturer Traders Association - Tamil Nadu and vice-president of the Bengal Association.

Das says the Southern Railway must run additional trains to cater to such rush from people. “The construction industry employs a number of people from Bengal and there should also be some initiative from the industry so that they can also be part of elections,” he adds.

Tamil Nadu Labour Welfare and Skill Development Department has already issued instructions that all employers across industries and commercial establishments, including private sector, shops and factories, must grant paid holiday to employees, casual workers and daily wage earners to travel to their hometowns when voting happens in their states.

‘Vote vandi’

And poll-related travel plans are not always about tickets. Soaring prices of flight tickets around this time and lack of certainty about train tickets are encouraging voters to undertake long road trips to cast the ballot. Increasingly many people are seen coming together to hire a bus or van and travel together. Anwar says he has noticed this trend in the last three years, where people pool in money and book a vehicle that will reach their hometown on voting day and they return on the same bus. Adds Anwar: “They are called ‘vote vandi’ (vote bus).”



ILLUSTRATION SATHEESH VELLINEZHI



The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair on April 11 and 12

The Hindu EducationPlus is conducting the 23rd edition of The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair on April 11 and 12 from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the Chennai Trade Centre, Convention Hall.

The exhaustive fair for parents and students from classes 9 to 12 will empower aspiring young minds to make informed career decisions from 40 plus institutions and help them choose the right courses and colleges. Top educational and financial institutions from across India will be present. Furthermore, career guidance sessions with domain experts will help people discuss their career plans. This annual fair is a great chance for students and parents to explore different career paths, learn about college admissions, and gain insights into various fields of study.

A plethora of options awaits students as they get ready to finish their schooling, much more than ever before. There are a wide range of courses to choose from, careers to aspire to, and areas of interest to delve into. In every edition, the fair has aimed to give students insights into several areas, cater to their interests, and open a world of educational opportunities for them. The latest edition of the career counselling fair will have all of this and make this experience possible for students by giving them the platform to engage with experts across diverse fields and representatives from various educational and financial institutions. Keeping up with the needs of the students, The Hindu EducationPlus has been organising career expos to aid students looking to pursue higher education both in India and overseas. Spot admissions and scholarships await the students at the fair along with surprise gifts for the first 200 entries on both the days. To know more about the sessions and the fair, contact: +91 90940 41021, 9962226550 and 9841298938.

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cation Plus Career Counselling Fair 2026" is powered by Hindustan Group of Institutions, Chennai and Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology, In Association with B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science & Technology and SRM Institute of Science & Technology, Tiruchirappalli. Associate partners are Amet University, Bharath Institute of Higher Education and Research, GRT Institute of Engineering and Technology, Mee-nakshi Academy of Higher Education & Research (MAHER), Symbiosis Skills and Professional University, Pune, The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India, Vels Institute of Science, Technology & Advanced Studies (VISTAS) and Vinayaka Mission's Research Foundation, Chennai Campus. To register: <https://newsth.live/THEPCFCED> or scan the QR code:



Travel free on buses and trains to Chepauk

As in previous years, Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) and Chennai Metro Rail Limited have launched an initiative to reduce traffic congestion and encourage people to use public transport on IPL match days in the city.

People with IPL match tickets can travel freely on MTC buses (whiteboard and deluxe) for three hours before and after the match.

MTC will operate buses from Anna Square bus terminus, Island Grounds (temporary) bus terminus, University of Madras haltover and near Omandurar Hospital on Anna Salai. From Anna Statue on Mount Road, MTC will operate shuttle services to the cricket stadium.

Metro trains

People intending to travel on the Metro

should possess a valid match ticket, said a CMRL release.

The ticket will enable a round-trip journey between their chosen stations and the Government Estate metro station.

Green line stations

The last train from the Government Estate metro station will depart at 1 a.m. towards Wimco Nagar Depot and Airport stations.

Commuters travelling towards green line stations (Corridor-2) shall interchange only at Chennai Central (during the special train services). The entry to the Estate station will be restricted 10 minutes before the last train for each line.

The matches are scheduled to be held at M. A. Chidambaram Cricket Stadium in Chepauk.

Hummer comes to India

Hummer, a US-based car battery jump starter, has entered the Indian market. The car jump starter stands out for its specifications, build quality, reliability, and safety features that protect both the device and the vehicle, said a press release.

The starter can also be used as a power bank for phones, laptops, inverters, and tire inflators, the release added.



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Refrain from throwing stones, or face action

The Chennai Division of Southern Railway has issued an advisory to the public to refrain from throwing stones at moving trains.

The unlawful acts pose a serious threat to passenger safety and railway staff, and cause damage to railway property and disruption to train services.

The acts are punishable offences under the Railways Act, 1989, Section 152, with imprisonment up to ten years or life imprisonment, and Section 154, which provides that acts endangering the safety of passengers are punishable by imprisonment and or a fine, a release from the transport body stated.

The division requests that parents, teachers, and social activists residing near railway tracks counsel and sensitize children and youth about the serious consequences of such acts.

Railway Protection Force (RPF) and Government Railway Police (GRP) have intensified patrolling in vulnerable locations across the division. Surveillance through CCTV and other monitoring mechanisms has been strengthened to identify and take action against offenders, the release added.

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